

Why Nicaea Mattered

A five-to-ten minute explainer for Week 2, August 23

Where to put it: at the top of Movement 2, right after the room says the Nicene Creed together. The order matters. They say the words first, then find out people were exiled over them.

What to cut to make room: the abstract “God is not a lonely monad” paragraph goes from a full beat down to two sentences, and you keep the Wesleyan accent at the end. This story answers “why should I care” better than the abstract version does, because it has people in it.

The script

1. Start with the awkward fact (1 minute)

Before there was a doctrine of the Trinity, there was a problem.

The first Christians were Jews. They said the Shema every day. Hear, O Israel, the Lord our God, the Lord is one. They would have died rather than worship anything that was not God, and a lot of them did.

And these same people prayed to Jesus. They sang to him. They baptized in his name. They called him Lord, which was the word their Bible used for God.

So for about three hundred years the church did something before it could explain it. It worshipped Jesus. Nicaea is what happened when somebody finally asked the obvious question out loud.

2. Arius, and why he was not a fool (1 to 2 minutes)

Around the year 318 a priest in Alexandria named Arius asked it. And I want you to hear his argument the way he would have made it, because we do not caricature people in this class.

Arius was defending God. He thought the Christians around him were sliding into having two gods, and he was trying to protect the oneness of God that Scripture insists on. His solution was elegant. The Son is the highest and first and greatest of everything God made. Before anything else existed, God brought forth the Son, and through the Son made everything else. The Son is glorious. The Son is worthy of honor. The Son is not eternal.

He had a slogan, and it is compact enough that it spread through the empire on its own. **There was when he was not.**

Meaning: go back far enough and there is only the Father. The Son has a beginning.

You can see why that caught on. It keeps God simple. It keeps God one. And it has verses. Arius could point to Colossians calling Christ the firstborn of all creation, to Proverbs 8 where wisdom says the Lord created me at the beginning of his work, to Jesus himself saying the Father is greater than I. This was not a man ignoring the Bible. This was a man reading it.

3. Why “created” broke everything (2 minutes)

Here is what Athanasius and the others saw, and it is the part worth slowing down on.

First problem. If the Son is created, then every Christian in this room is an idolater.

Not confused. Not imprecise. An idolater. Because we are on our knees in front of something that is not God. The church had been praying to Jesus for three centuries. Arius’s position did not just adjust a footnote. It said that the central act of Christian worship was a violation of the first commandment.

Second problem, and this is the one that decided it. If the Son is created, then a creature is saving us.

Athanasius’s argument runs like this. Only God can forgive sins against God. Only God can defeat death. Only the one who made us can remake us. If the one who came for us is a creature, however exalted, then a creature is doing the one job in the universe that only God can do. Athanasius put it in *On the Incarnation* in a line people have been quoting for seventeen hundred years, and translations vary a bit, but it is close to this: he became human so that we might be made divine. If the first half of that sentence is a creature, the second half never happens.

So the fight looks like it is about metaphysics. It is not. It is about whether the thing you did on Sunday morning was worship or idolatry, and whether the person you are trusting with your death can actually carry it.

4. The word they picked, and the problem with it (2 minutes)

In 325 the emperor Constantine, who mostly wanted his empire to stop fighting, convened a council at Nicaea, which is in modern Turkey. Somewhere between two hundred fifty and three hundred eighteen bishops came. A number of them arrived with scars and missing eyes from the persecutions that had ended barely a decade earlier.

And they hit a wall.

Every biblical word they tried, Arius's supporters could sign. Call the Son the image of God. They would sign it. Call him the Word of God. They would sign it. Call him from God, begotten of the Father, even God. They would sign it and mean something else by it, because in their reading a creature can be all of those things.

So the council reached for a word that is not in the Bible.

Homoousios. Say it with me. Hoh-moh-OO-see-os. It means *of the same being, of one substance*. Not similar to God. Not godlike. The same.

I want you to sit with how strange that move is. A room full of bishops, in the most important doctrinal decision the church has ever made, defended a biblical truth with a word that is not in the Bible. They did it because every biblical word had become slippery, and they needed one that could not be signed in bad faith.

That is the thing your Baptist friends and your Presbyterian friends and your Catholic friends have all quietly inherited, whatever anybody says about no creed but the Bible. When we recite the creed in worship and say *of one Being with the Father*, that is homoousios in English.

5. Begotten, not made (1 to 2 minutes)

And then the creed puts the whole argument in three words that you can explain to a child.

Begotten, not made.

Think about what those two words actually do in ordinary life.

When you *make* something, you make something other than yourself. I can make a table. The table is not a person. It is wood, it is other, it has a beginning, and it exists because I decided it should.

When you *beget*, you produce your own kind. My children are not my projects. They are not made out of a different material than I am. They are human because I am human. Same nature, no exceptions.

So the creed is not being poetic. It is closing a door. Say the Son was *made* and you have said he is a creature, another thing God decided to produce, of a different order than God. Say the Son is *begotten* and you have said he is of the same kind as the Father, which is the whole point.

And then the creed guards the flank, because somebody will ask when the begetting happened. So it stacks up the light images. *God from God, Light from Light, true God from true God*. Think about a flame and the light coming off it. The light is not later than the flame. The flame did not manufacture it out of other material. There is no moment when you have a

flame with no light. That is the picture. Eternally from the Father, never after the Father, never other than the Father.

Which is exactly the sentence Arius could not sign. The creed even ends with the council naming his slogan and condemning it by name. Anyone who says *there was when he was not* is outside.

6. The one letter (1 minute)

Now, the famous part, and I want to tell it to you accurately rather than the way it usually gets told.

There is a second Greek word, one letter different. **Homoiousios**. Hoh-moy-OO-see-os. One extra iota, which is the Greek i. And that iota changes *of the same being* into *of similar being*.

People love to say the whole Christian world split over a single letter, and there is real truth in it, because that is genuinely the difference between the Son being God and the Son being the most God-like thing there is.

Here is the honest version. That word was not the fight at Nicaea in 325. It came later. After the council, when the argument would not die, a group of bishops in the 350s offered *similar* as a compromise everybody could live with. And it almost won. For most of the middle of that century the anti-Nicene side had the emperors, the councils, and the numbers.

So the story is not that the church met once, voted, and settled it. Nicaea was 325. The creed we actually say did not reach its settled form until Constantinople in 381. Fifty-six years. Athanasius was run out of his own city five separate times for holding the line. There was a stretch where a Roman historian could look around and say the world had woken up and found itself Arian.

The one-letter version is a good story and it is worth telling. Just tell it as the thing that happened after Nicaea, because that is what makes the whole century make sense.

7. Why it was the catalyst (1 to 2 minutes)

Three things came out of that room, and all three of them are still running.

One. It settled what Christian worship is. Every time this congregation prays to Jesus, we are standing on a decision made in 325. Nicaea is the reason that is worship and not idolatry.

Two. It established that the church would define its own edges, in its own words, together. Nicaea is the first time the whole church met and said, in binding language, this is what we mean and that is outside. Every creed after it, every confession, every doctrinal standard we have, is working in a groove Nicaea cut.

And notice what that means for what we talked about last week. The words you just recited are not in the Bible. The church chose them, to protect what it found in the Bible, and then bound itself to what it chose. That is not a departure from Scripture's authority. That is the church doing exactly what I said last week it does. The creed in your hand is the best evidence I have for the position I was arguing.

Three. It set the shape of every argument we have left in this class. From here on, every tradition in this room agrees about what we just said. Catholic, Baptist, Presbyterian, Methodist, Orthodox. What is coming for the next four weeks is a family argument among people who all say these words. That is a completely different kind of disagreement than the one Arius was having, and knowing the difference is most of what I want you to take out of tonight.

Lines you can use as they are

The first Christians worshipped Jesus for three centuries before they had the vocabulary to explain why they were allowed to.

Arius was not attacking the faith. He thought he was defending the oneness of God, and he had verses.

The council picked a word that is not in the Bible, because every word that is in the Bible had become slippery.

When you make something, you make something other than yourself. When you beget, you produce your own kind. That is the entire argument in two words.

Nicaea did not end the fight. It started a fifty-six year one.

Accuracy notes, for you and not the room

The spelling. It is *homoousios* and *homoiousios*, both with an s at the end. Hoh-moh-OO-see-os and hoh-moy-OO-see-os. The difference is the iota, the Greek letter i, sitting inside the second one.

The iota story needs its timestamp. Homoiousios was not on the table at Nicaea in 325. It surfaced as a mediating position in the 350s, associated with Basil of Ancyra and the Synod of Ancyra in 358, and it had the numbers at Seleucia in 359. If you tell the one-letter story as if it happened on the council floor, somebody who has read a book will catch it. Telling it correctly is also the better story, because it explains why the fight took another two generations.

Kill the Constantine myth if it comes up, and it might. Constantine convened the council and wanted unity. He did not write the creed, he was

not a theologian, and he did not impose the outcome. The vote was lopsided. Two bishops, Theonas and Secundus, refused to sign and were exiled with Arius. And afterward Constantine himself drifted toward the Arian side and recalled Arius from exile, which is not what you would expect from a man who had rigged it. Nicaea also did not decide which books are in the Bible and did not invent the divinity of Jesus. If somebody brings up a novel or a documentary, that is the short answer.

On the numbers. Tradition says 318 bishops. Scholars put the real figure somewhere between 250 and 318. Say “somewhere between two hundred fifty and three hundred” and you are safe.

On the creed we actually recite. What the room will say is properly the Niceno-Constantinopolitan Creed, the 325 creed as expanded at Constantinople in 381, which is where most of the language about the Holy Spirit comes from. Worth one sentence if you want it, since Movement 3 goes to the Spirit and this hands you the bridge.

On the Athanasius line. *On the Incarnation*, section 54. English translations vary, commonly rendered along the lines of “he became human that we might become divine” or “he was made man that we might be made God.” Give it as the sense of what he wrote rather than as a fixed quotation and you are on solid ground.

A related line you may want, and it is from a different fight. Gregory of Nazianzus wrote that what is not assumed is not healed. That is about the incarnation and Apollinarianism rather than about Nicaea, and it belongs to the road toward Chalcedon. Use it if it helps, and say whose it is.

The clock

Five minutes is sections 1, 3, 4, and 5. That is the spine and it works on its own.

Ten minutes adds section 2, so Arius gets a fair hearing, and sections 6 and 7, which is where the payoff is.

If you have to choose one thing to protect, protect section 5. Begotten not made is the sentence they will still have in a month.

The Nicene Line

Where the family agrees, and where the family ends.

ALL EIGHT CONFESSIONAL FAMILIES CONFESS THIS

One God in three persons, coeternal and of one being.
Christ fully God and fully human. Begotten, not made.

Catholic

Orthodox

Anglican

Lutheran

Wesleyan / Methodist

Reformed

Baptist

Pentecostal

The one real fault line inside the agreement is the *filioque*, the Western addition saying the Spirit proceeds from the Father *and the Son*. The East never accepted it, and it is part of what split the church in 1054.

OUTSIDE THE NICENE CONSENSUS

Oneness Pentecostal

One God who reveals himself as Father, Son, and Spirit rather than existing eternally as three persons. Baptism in Jesus' name.

ANCIENT PARALLEL: modalism, named and rejected in the third century.

Latter-day Saints

Father, Son, and Holy Ghost as three distinct beings united in purpose. An embodied Father. An open canon.

ANCIENT PARALLEL: none clean. This is its own nineteenth-century thing.

Jehovah's Witnesses

Christ as God's first and highest creation rather than eternal God. There was when he was not.

ANCIENT PARALLEL: Arianism, the exact position Nicaea was called to answer.

Unitarian / progressive

No binding creed. The divinity of Christ held as one interpretive option among several rather than as a confession.

ANCIENT PARALLEL: the radical Reformation, then New England Unitarianism.

The point: for four more weeks we argue inside the band. Tonight is the only night we look at the line under it. Every tradition above that rule can say the creed you just said. That is a completely different kind of disagreement than the one Arius was having, and knowing the difference is most of what tonight is for.

Who Gets Saved and How

The plain English version

Six to eight minutes. Use it at the top of Movement 1, before any of the vocabulary. Then the technical words land on something the room is already holding, instead of the other way around.

Start with the agreement, because it is almost everything

Before I tell you what Calvinists and Methodists argue about, I want to tell you what they agree on.

Nobody in this argument thinks you can save yourself. Not one person in it. Not Calvin, not Wesley, not your Baptist neighbor, not the Catholic church. Every single one of them believes that if God does not come and get you, you are not coming.

That is worth sitting with for a second, because it means this whole four-hundred-year fight is a family argument between people who agree on the thing that matters most. Nobody here is teaching that you climb up to God. They are arguing about **how far gone you were** and **what God did about it**.

That is the whole thing. Three questions. Let me give you a picture and then the questions.

The picture

You are in the water. Way out. Nobody saw you go in.

Everybody in this argument agrees you are not swimming back. Everybody agrees somebody has to come get you. Hold that.

Now here are the three questions the traditions actually differ on, and I want you to notice how short they are.

Question one: how far gone are you?

One answer is that you are already at the bottom. Not struggling. Not tired. Dead. A dead man does not wave for help, and he does not want to. He has no preferences at all anymore. If he is coming out of that water, it is

because somebody went to the bottom and got him and did CPR on the sand, and he had nothing to do with any of it.

The other answer is that you are still going under, and you are not coming back up on your own. Also fatal. Also hopeless without rescue. But there is a difference between a body and a person who is drowning.

Notice: both answers are grim. Nobody here says you are basically fine and could paddle back if you tried. That is not one of the options. When we say the word **depravity** later tonight, this is all it means. Not that you are as bad as a person could be. That every part of you is affected, including the part that would have decided to swim.

Think of a compass someone put a magnet next to. It still works. The needle still moves, it still points, it still looks like a compass. It is just never going to point true north again, and it cannot fix itself. That is depravity. It is not that the compass is broken beyond recognition. It is that the one thing you needed it for is the one thing it cannot do.

Question two: when God comes for you, can you say no?

Here is where it gets interesting, and here is where most people misunderstand the other side.

One answer: no, and thank God. If you were dead at the bottom, then the rescue is not a negotiation. God does not pull up alongside and make an offer. He makes you alive, and a person who has just been made alive wants to live. So when you come to on that beach, you are gasping and grateful and reaching for him, and every bit of that is genuinely yours. It just was not first.

I want to be careful here, because this position gets caricatured constantly. It does not mean God drags people to heaven kicking and screaming. Nobody teaches that. It means God changes what you want, and then you want it. From the inside it feels exactly like your own decision, because it is your own decision. It is just not the first move.

The other answer: yes, you can say no. God gets to you. God gets your head above the water. God does the thing you could never have done. And then there is a hand, and you can take it or you can push it away.

That second answer is ours, and it costs us something, so let me pay the cost out loud. If you can say no, then something real hangs on the saying. And the honest question back is: so is the difference between saved and not saved finally you? Are you the reason?

And Wesley's answer, which I think is right, is no. Because you did not get your own head above water. You were not standing on a dock deciding whether to jump in and help yourself. You were unconscious and going down and somebody found you. **The only reason you have a hand free to reach with is that God put it there.**

That is the word we are going to use tonight, and it is worth learning: **prevenient grace.** It is an old word that just means *the grace that goes before*. Before you asked. Before you knew his name. Before you were interested.

Here is how I would test whether you believe it. Think about the first time you actually wanted God. Not church. Not your parents' church. Wanted him. Now ask yourself where that wanting came from, and whether you manufactured it. Nobody ever does. Nobody wakes up one morning, from a standing start, and generates a hunger for God out of nothing. By the time you went looking, you had already been found once. That is the whole doctrine.

Question three: who did he come for?

One answer: he came for specific people. The rescue was not a general offer posted on a sign. He came into that water with names, and he got every one of them, which is why the rescue never fails. If Christ actually died for someone, that person is saved, or else something did not work.

The other answer: he came for the beach. Everybody in the water. The rescue is genuinely for all of them, and it is applied to the ones who take the hand.

That is our answer, and it is why we say things like *whosoever will*.

Now the part that makes the whole night make sense

Here is what I want you to see, and it is the reason I put those three questions in that order.

They are not three separate opinions. They are one.

Answer question one with "dead at the bottom," and the other two answers are already decided for you. A dead man cannot be given a choice, so the rescue has to be one-sided. And a rescue that cannot fail has to be aimed at particular people, or else everyone would be saved. It is a genuinely tight system. That is not a weakness of it. That is why smart, serious, godly people hold it.

Answer question one with “drowning,” and the other two follow just as tightly the other way. Somebody who is drowning can still be handed something. And if the hand can be refused, it can be held out to everyone.

So when you hear a Calvinist and a Methodist argue about limited atonement, they are not really arguing about limited atonement. They are arguing about question one, and they have been since the first sentence. Everything after that is bookkeeping.

Which is why I want to say something about the people on the other side of this. They are not being stubborn and they are not soft on grace. If anything the Reformed answer takes grace more seriously at the front end than ours does, and honest Wesleyans should admit that. What we think they give up is that God genuinely wants everybody and genuinely offers himself to everybody. What they think we give up is the certainty that the rescue actually works. Both of those are real losses. Anyone who tells you their side pays no price is selling something.

Why this matters on Tuesday

Three ways, and they are not abstract.

How you pray for people. If God is already in the water with your son, already working, already ahead of you, then your prayer is not you talking God into caring. It is you joining something already underway. That changes how long you are willing to wait. Prevenient grace is the reason you do not give up on people at year eleven.

How you talk to somebody far from church. You are not carrying God to them. He got there first. Your job is smaller and better than you thought: to notice out loud what he is already doing in a person, and name it.

What you do with your own bad days. If you are Reformed, the comfort is that it never depended on you. If you are Wesleyan, the comfort is that the hand is still there and it has been there the whole time. Both of those are real comforts. Neither of them is you holding on hard enough.

Two smaller pictures, if you want them

On the words “free will.” Both sides say they believe in free will and they mean different things, so ask before you fight. Try this. Tonight you will pick something for dinner, and nobody will make you. That is free. But did you pick what you wanted? Or did you just want what you wanted, and then go get it? A Calvinist says you are free in the first sense, always. You do exactly

what you want, every time. He just says God is the one who decides what you want.

On the word “election.” In the Bible, being chosen is almost always being chosen *for* something. God picks Abraham, and it is not a membership card, it is an assignment on behalf of everybody else. Before we argue about whether God picked you, it is worth noticing that in Scripture being picked mostly means being handed a job.

On the word “predestination.” Every tradition in this room believes in it, including ours. It is in Romans and Ephesians and you do not get to skip it. What we are arguing about is not whether God decides things ahead of time. It is what he decides, and on what basis.

Week 3 | The vocabulary

Terms to define carefully, in the order they build

Every one of these gets misheard in a normal church room, and most of them get misheard in the same direction. The **common misunderstanding** line under each is the part worth memorizing, because that is the sentence that does the work.

Define a word *before* you use it, and define it twice if it has a common meaning that differs from its technical one. Free will, total depravity, and predestination are all in that category.

The two master words

Everything tonight is one argument wearing eight costumes. If the room only keeps two words, keep these.

Monergism

- From the Greek for *one* and *work*. One worker.
- Salvation is God's work from beginning to end. The human contributes nothing, not even the decision to accept.
- Held by the Reformed, and by Lutherans on the front end.
- **Common misunderstanding:** that it makes people robots. Its defenders would say the person genuinely chooses, and that God is what makes the choosing possible.
- **Say it this way:** God does all of it, including the part that feels like your idea.

Synergism

- *Working together*. Two parties, though not two equals.
 - God initiates and enables; the person genuinely responds, and the response is real enough that it could have gone otherwise.
 - Held by Catholics, Orthodox, Wesleyans, and most Baptists.
 - **Common misunderstanding:** that we are claiming to contribute something meritorious, so that salvation is half earned. Wesleyans answer that even the response is produced by grace, so nobody gets a bill or a trophy.
 - **Say it this way:** God moves first, always. But he does not answer for you.
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Where a person starts

Original sin

- The condition every human is born into as a result of the fall, distinct from the individual sins a person commits.
- Nearly everybody in tonight's conversation affirms it. It is not a Calvinist distinctive.
- The Eastern churches prefer *ancestral sin* and frame the inheritance as corruption and mortality rather than inherited guilt. Worth knowing if an Orthodox friend comes up.
- **Common misunderstanding:** that it means babies are guilty of something they did. It names a condition and a direction, not a rap sheet.

Total depravity

- **This is the most misunderstood term in the whole class.** Define it before you use it.
 - It does **not** mean people are as evil as they could possibly be, or that nothing good or beautiful remains in anyone. That position is called utter depravity and essentially nobody holds it.
 - *Total* describes the **extent**, not the intensity. Sin has touched every part of a person: mind, will, affections, desires. No faculty was left clean and neutral.
 - The consequence is the point: a person cannot, from their own natural resources, turn to God.
 - **Methodists affirm this.** Our own Articles of Religion say a person cannot turn and prepare himself by his own natural strength. Say that out loud tonight, because the room will assume we disagree here and we do not.
 - **Where the fight actually starts:** not with the diagnosis, but with what God does about it, and for how many.
 - **Say it this way:** total means every room in the house has smoke damage, not that the house burned to the ground.
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The will

Free will

- The single most slippery word tonight, because **both sides use it and mean different things.** Name that before you go further.
- **Libertarian freedom:** at the moment of choosing, the person genuinely could have done otherwise. This is what most people in the room think the words mean.
- **Compatibilist freedom:** the person always freely does what they most want to do, and what they most want is itself determined. You

are free because nobody is forcing you, even though you were never going to choose differently.

- The Reformed usually hold the compatibilist version. So a Calvinist will tell you he believes in free will, and he is not being slippery. He means the second thing.
 - The Wesleyan position: the will is **not naturally free** toward God. It is freed, by grace, and only by grace. Wesley treats free will as a gift rather than as standard equipment.
 - **Say it this way:** ask what somebody means by free before you agree or disagree with them about it.
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Grace, and its adjectives

Grace

- God's favor and active help, given to people who have not earned it and cannot.
- Not a substance you accumulate. God's own presence and power at work in a person.
- Everybody tonight agrees grace is necessary and unearned. The adjectives are where they part.

Prevenient grace

- **The Wesleyan keystone.** If the room keeps one technical term from tonight, this is it.
- *Prevenient* just means *going before*. Wesley often wrote **preventing grace**, using the older English sense of preceding rather than blocking. Flag that or somebody will read an old sermon and get it backwards.
- The claim: God is already at work in every person, before they ask, before they know his name, restoring enough freedom that a real response becomes possible.
- It is **universal**, given to everyone, and it is **not by itself saving**. It opens the door. It does not carry you through it.
- It is what lets a Methodist hold John 6:44 and 1 Timothy 2:4 in the same hand without flinching. Nobody comes unless drawn, and God draws everybody.
- **This is also our defense against the charge of semi-Pelagianism.** See below.
- **Say it this way:** by the time you go looking for God, he has been working on you for years.

Irresistible grace, or effectual calling

- The Reformed position: when God calls a person savingly, that call accomplishes what it was sent to do. It does not fail.

- **Present it fairly.** It does not mean God drags people in against their will. It means God so changes what the person wants that they come willingly. From the inside it feels entirely like your own decision.
- Many Reformed theologians dislike *irresistible* for exactly that reason and prefer **effectual calling**. Using their preferred term costs you nothing and buys a lot.
- **Say it this way:** God does not overrule your will, he changes what you want.

Resistible grace

- The Wesleyan and Catholic position: grace can be genuinely refused, at the start and later.
 - The cost we accept: if grace can be refused, then something real depends on the refusing, and we have to explain why some refuse without making the difference a matter of merit.
 - **Say it this way:** God will not make you stay, because that is not what love does.
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Regeneration, and the order of events

Regeneration, or the new birth

- God making a spiritually dead person alive. Not a decision, not a feeling. A change in what a person actually is.
- Everybody tonight believes in it. **The fight is about when it happens.**

Ordo salutis, the order of salvation

- The technical name for the sequence: calling, regeneration, faith, justification, sanctification, and so on.
- Most people have never thought about the order and are surprised that it is a question at all. It is the hinge of the whole Calvinist system.

Regeneration before faith, or after?

- **Reformed:** regeneration comes **first**. A dead person cannot believe, so God makes them alive, and then they believe. This is why grace is effectual: a made-alive person *will* believe. The system is genuinely tight here, and if you grant this one move most of the rest follows.
- **Wesleyan and Arminian:** prevenient grace comes first and enables faith, and regeneration comes **with** faith rather than before it. God's initiative is fully preserved; it just takes the form of enabling rather than of completing.
- **Baptist, traditional:** faith, then regeneration.
- **Roman Catholic:** ordinarily tied to baptism, where regeneration is given.

- **Say it this way:** everybody agrees God has to make you alive. The question is whether he does it before you believe or in the act of believing.
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Choosing

Election

- God's choosing of a people for himself. The word is thoroughly biblical and nobody gets to skip it.
- In Scripture the primary sense is **corporate and vocational**: God chooses Abraham, Israel, the church, and chooses them *for* something on behalf of everybody else. Being chosen is a job before it is a status.
- The systematic argument is about a narrower question: on what basis does God elect individuals?
- **Say it this way:** in the Bible, being chosen almost always means being chosen for a job.

The elect

- The noun that goes with the verb. **Election** is the act of choosing. **The elect** are the people it happened to.
- In the New Testament the word is almost always plural and corporate. It names a people rather than reading out a list. Mark 13, Romans 8:33, Colossians 3:12, and 1 Peter 1 all use it that way.
- **Reformed:** a definite number of particular persons, known to God and fixed from eternity.
- **Wesleyan and Arminian:** those who are in Christ by faith. The category is entirely real; what determines membership is being in Christ rather than a prior roster.
- **Common misunderstanding, and it is the pastorally dangerous one:** that there is a secret list, that you might not be on it, and that the Christian life is the project of finding out. No responsible Reformed pastor teaches people to go looking for their name. They point to Christ and to the fruit of a changed life.
- Be ready for the question underneath it, because somebody in the room has carried it a long time: *how do I know I am one of them?* Do not answer it with mechanics. Wesley's answer is the Spirit's own witness, and it is where week four goes.
- **Say it this way:** election is what God does. The elect are the people he did it to. And nobody was ever meant to figure out which one they are by staring at themselves.

Predestination

- God's determining beforehand of a person's destiny.

- The word is in the New Testament, in Romans 8 and Ephesians 1. **Every tradition here has a doctrine of predestination.** Nobody gets to say they do not believe in it. They differ on what it means.
- **Common misunderstanding:** that only Calvinists believe in it. Say plainly that a Methodist believes in predestination too and then explain what we mean by it.

Unconditional election

- God's choice rests on nothing whatsoever in the person, including nothing God foresees them doing. It is free, sovereign, and unexplained.
- Reformed, and Lutheran with a large qualification.
- The pastoral strength, and give it honestly: if the choice rests on nothing in you, then nothing in you can unmake it. That is a real comfort to some people and you should say so.

Conditional election

- God elects **in view of foreseen faith**. Looking down history, God elects those he sees will believe.
- Wesleyan, Arminian, traditional Southern Baptist, Orthodox.
- **Common misunderstanding, and it is the one that will be thrown at you:** that this makes us elect ourselves and reduces God to a spectator taking attendance. Two answers. First, God still does the electing. Second, the faith he foresees is faith his own prevenient grace made possible, so nothing here is self-generated.
- **Say it this way:** God chooses. He just does not choose without regard to you.

Foreknowledge

- God's knowing beforehand.
- The Arminian reading: God knows in advance who will believe, and elects accordingly.
- The Reformed reading, and know this one or Romans 8 will ambush you: the Hebrew sense of *knowing* is relational, so "whom he foreknew" means whom he **set his love upon beforehand** rather than whom he had advance information about. On that reading foreknowledge is not prediction, it is choosing.
- **Say it this way:** the argument over Romans 8:29 is really an argument about what the word *knew* is doing.

Double predestination

- The claim that God does not merely elect some to salvation but also decrees the rest to damnation.
- Two versions, and the difference matters:

- **Equal ultimacy, or symmetrical.** God actively works both destinies the same way. A minority position, and many Calvinists reject it warmly.
- **Asymmetrical, or preterition.** God actively chooses some and **passes over** the rest, leaving them to the judgment they were already headed for. This is the more common confessional Reformed position.
- **Lutherans explicitly reject double predestination.** Unconditional election to salvation only, never to damnation. That is a genuinely useful third seat if you want to show the room this is not a two-option question.
- Wesleyans reject it outright. Wesley preached against it hard, and it is the sharpest thing he ever said about Calvinism.
- **Common misunderstanding:** that every Calvinist holds the symmetrical version. Most do not. Ask before you assume.

Reprobation

- The technical term for the other side of double predestination: those not elected.
 - Confessional Reformed language usually speaks of God passing them by rather than of God creating people in order to damn them. State it that way and you are being fair.
-

What the cross accomplished, and for whom

Limited atonement, or particular or definite redemption

- Christ died with the intent of actually securing salvation for the elect, rather than making salvation merely available to everyone.
- **Use their word.** *Limited* is the outsider's label and it sounds stingy. Reformed writers usually say **particular redemption** or **definite atonement**. Using the in-house term signals you did the reading.
- The internal logic, which is worth respecting: if Christ actually paid for someone's sin, and that person is not saved, then either the payment failed or it was never made for them.
- Note this is the **least held** of the five points. Many Calvinists are what gets called four-point.

Unlimited or general atonement

- Christ died for everyone; the benefit is applied when a person believes.
- Wesleyan, Catholic, Orthodox, Lutheran, traditional Baptist.

Sufficient for all, efficient for the elect

- The old formula, and it softens the binary usefully. The cross is of infinite worth and adequate for every person who ever lived, and it actually saves those who come to it.
 - Plenty of Calvinists say this and it sounds a great deal like what we say. Point that out when the room is getting tribal.
-

The labels, and where they came from

The Remonstrance, 1610

- Five articles published by the followers of Jacobus Arminius after his death, asking the Dutch church to revise its confession.
- **The Arminians went first.** That is the fact people find most surprising.

The Synod of Dort and the Canons of Dort, 1618 to 1619

- The Dutch Reformed reply, answering the Remonstrants article by article. Five heads of doctrine, matched to their five.
- So the famous five points of Calvinism are a **response to five points of Arminianism**, not the other way around. That flip is worth two minutes of anybody's evening.

TULIP

- Total depravity, Unconditional election, Limited atonement, Irresistible grace, Perseverance of the saints.
- **Not Calvin's.** He never saw it. It is a twentieth-century English mnemonic, and it does not even follow the order of the Canons of Dort.
- Useful as a memory aid. Not useful as history, and a well-read Calvinist will wince if you present it as the tradition's own summary.

Arminianism

- After Jacobus Arminius, a Dutch Reformed pastor and professor who died in 1609.
 - **Wesley was a proud Arminian.** He named his magazine *The Arminian Magazine*. This is our family name, not an insult somebody stuck on us.
 - Worth knowing: Arminius himself was closer to the Reformed tradition than many of his later followers, and he thought of himself as reforming it from inside.
-

The two heresies to keep straight

Not academic trivia. This is the accusation Wesleyans get, and you should be able to answer it in one sentence.

Pelagianism

- Named for Pelagius. Humans are born morally neutral and can take the first step toward God unaided. Grace helps, but it is not strictly necessary to begin.
- Condemned in 418.
- **Nobody in this conversation holds it.** Do not let the word get thrown around as an insult.

Semi-Pelagianism

- The subtler one. The **human takes the first step** and God's grace comes alongside afterward to carry it through.
 - Condemned at the **Second Council of Orange in 529**.
 - **This is what Wesleyans get accused of**, and it is the accusation to be ready for.
 - **The answer is prevenient grace, and it is a complete answer.** We do not say the human moves first. We say God moves first, in every person, universally, before anybody asks. Semi-Pelagianism puts the first step on the human. Prevenient grace exists precisely to deny that. The whole doctrine is built to keep us on the right side of Orange.
 - **Say it this way:** if you think we teach that people reach for God on their own, you have not heard the word prevenient yet.
-

Two more you may want

Molinism, or middle knowledge

- Named for Luis de Molina, a Jesuit. God knows not only what will happen but what any free creature **would freely choose** in any possible circumstance, and God arranges the circumstances accordingly.
- The attempt to hold total sovereignty and genuine freedom together without either collapsing.
- Behind Rome's willingness to leave the tension standing. In the *de Auxiliis* controversy, roughly 1581 to 1607, Dominicans and Jesuits fought this out for a quarter century, and in 1607 Pope Paul V ended it by permitting both positions and forbidding each side to condemn the other. **Neither was condemned.**
- That is a genuinely interesting posture and worth naming: sometimes a church decides a question is better held than settled.

Decisionism

- Conversion understood as a discrete human decision at an identifiable moment, usually tied to an invitation or an altar call.
 - Common across revivalist and non-denominational churches and shapes a great deal of what your people have absorbed.
 - Fairness note: this is a description used mostly by critics rather than a label anybody picks for themselves. Say what the practice is rather than leading with the term.
-

Five traps to watch for tonight

1. **Total depravity.** The room will hear “as bad as possible.” Correct it immediately, then say we affirm the doctrine.
2. **Free will.** Both sides claim it. Ask what somebody means before agreeing or disagreeing.
3. **Predestination.** People think it belongs to Calvinists. It is in the New Testament and we have a doctrine of it too.
4. **Limited atonement.** Use *particular redemption* when describing the Reformed position, and note that plenty of Calvinists do not hold it.
5. **Semi-Pelagianism.** If somebody has heard that Methodists are semi-Pelagian, the one-sentence answer is prevenient grace. God moves first.

Twelve Words for Tonight

Keep this beside you. Nobody is expected to memorize any of it.

BEFORE ANY OF IT: nobody in this argument thinks you can save yourself. Every tradition on this page agrees that if God does not come and get you, you are not coming. The fight is over how far gone you were and what God did about it.

Grace

God's help and favor, given to people who did not earn it and could not. Everyone here agrees grace is necessary. All the arguments are about the adjectives.

Monergism & synergism ONE WORKER, OR TWO

Monergism: God does all of it, including the part that felt like your idea. **Synergism:** God moves first and makes everything possible, and you genuinely respond. Every other word on this page is a footnote to these two.

Total depravity

Not "as bad as a person could be." It means sin touched every part of you, including the part that would have decided to look for God, so you cannot start on your own. *Methodists believe this too.*

Prevenient grace THE METHODIST KEYSTONE

The grace that goes before. God is already at work in every person, before they ask and before they know his name. It is the reason you were ever able to want him at all.

Free will

Careful, both sides claim it and mean different things. Some mean you genuinely could have chosen otherwise. Others mean you always freely do what you most want, while God is the one who decides what you want. Ask which before you argue.

Regeneration THE NEW BIRTH

God making a spiritually dead person alive. Everybody believes in it. The fight is over *when*: before you believe, or in the act of believing.

Election

God's choosing of a people for himself. In Scripture, being chosen almost always means being chosen *for* something, a job on behalf of everybody else.

The elect

The people God has chosen. Election is the act; the elect are the people it happened to. **Not** a secret list you are supposed to go hunting for your own name on.

Unconditional & conditional election

Unconditional: God's choice rests on nothing in you at all.

Reformed. **Conditional:** God elects in view of the faith he sees coming, faith his own grace made possible. *Methodist, Arminian, traditional Baptist.*

Predestination

God determining beforehand. The word is in Romans and Ephesians, so *every* tradition here has a doctrine of it, ours included. What we argue about is what it means.

Double predestination

The further claim that God decrees not only who is saved but who is lost. Plenty of Calvinists reject the strong version of it. Lutherans reject it. We reject it, and Wesley said so loudly.

Limited & unlimited atonement WHO THE CROSS WAS FOR

Limited, or particular redemption: Christ died to actually secure his own people. **Unlimited:** Christ died for everyone, and it is applied when a person believes. *Ours is unlimited.*

IF YOU KEEP ONE THING: prevenient grace. It means God got there first, in every single person, before anybody asked. It is why a Methodist can say both that nobody comes to God on their own steam and that the door is genuinely open to everyone. And it is the answer to anyone who says we teach that people reach for God by themselves. We do not. God moves first. Always.

Who Gets Saved and How

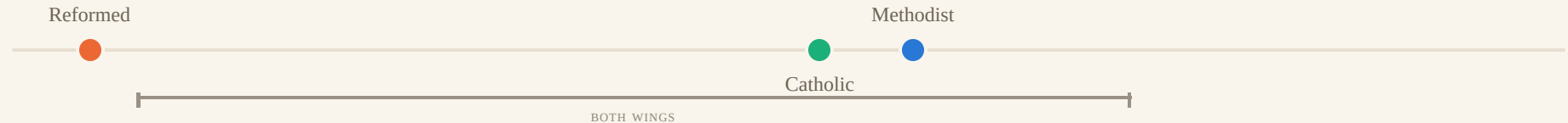
Four questions, one argument. Where each tradition lands, and why the order never changes.

● Methodist ● Roman Catholic ● Reformed & New Calvinist — Southern Baptist, spanning both wings

The human will

BOUND UNTIL GOD ACTS

FREED TO RESPOND



Election

UNCONDITIONAL, GOD'S CHOICE ALONE

CONDITIONAL, IN VIEW OF FORESEEN FAITH



Grace

CANNOT FINALLY BE REFUSED

CAN BE RESISTED



The cross, and who it was for

FOR THE ELECT

FOR EVERYONE



THE FINDING: the order never changes. Reformed on the left, Rome in the middle, Methodists on the right, every single line. These are not four independent opinions. They are one conviction about who moves first, showing up in four places. And the gray bracket is why two Baptist churches on the same road can disagree about this: on these questions the Convention contains both answers.

The same four questions, in words

Question	Reformed & New Calvinist	Roman Catholic	Methodist
The human will	Total depravity. The will is in bondage until regeneration.	Wounded by sin, but able to cooperate with grace.	Depravity is real. Prevenient grace frees the will to respond.
Election	Unconditional election. Strict Calvinism adds double predestination.	Predestination affirmed and held together with real freedom. The tension is left standing.	Conditional election in view of foreseen faith. Whosoever will.
Grace	Irresistible and effectual, given to the elect.	Infused and cooperated with, mediated through the sacraments.	Prevenient and resistible. Grace goes before and enables everyone.
The cross, and who it was for	Limited or particular. Christ died for the elect.	Sufficient for all, applied through the Church's means.	Unlimited. Christ died for everyone.
Southern Baptist	The Convention contains both. The traditional statement is conditional election and unlimited atonement, close to the Methodist position. The New Calvinist wing holds every point of Dort.		

Positions are relative, not measured. There is no scale on these lines on purpose. Drawn from each tradition's own confessional statements: the Canons of Dort and the Westminster Confession, the Catechism of the Catholic Church, the Baptist Faith and Message with the 2012 Traditional Statement, and the Articles of Religion. A v1 for Woods to adjust.

One Question, Three Times

You are in the water. Everything else follows from how far gone you were.

WHAT EVERY SINGLE TRADITION HERE AGREES ON

Nobody in this argument thinks you can save yourself. If God does not come and get you, you are not coming.

	IF YOU WERE DEAD AT THE BOTTOM	IF YOU WERE DROWNING
How far gone are you? DEPRAVITY	Dead. A dead man does not wave for help and does not want to. He has no preferences left at all.	Going under. Just as fatal, and just as hopeless alone. But there is a difference between a body and a person still sinking.
When God comes for you, can you say no? GRACE, AND THE WILL	No, and thank God. He does not pull alongside and make an offer. He makes you alive, and a person just made alive wants to live. The gasping on the beach is genuinely yours. It just was not first.	Yes. He gets to you. He gets your head above water, which you could never have done. Then there is a hand, and you can take it or push it away.
Who did he come for? ELECTION, AND THE CROSS	Particular people. He came into the water with names and got every one of them, which is why the rescue never fails.	The whole beach. Genuinely for everyone in the water, and applied to the ones who take the hand.

THE POINT: these are not three opinions, they are one. Answer the first question and the other two are already decided. That is why a Calvinist and a Methodist arguing about the cross are not really arguing about the cross. They have been arguing about the first line since the first sentence, and everything after it is bookkeeping. It is also why both columns hold together, and why serious people live in each of them.

Where the other two sit. Rome stands closer to the right-hand column and declines to resolve the tension, which is itself a position and an old one. The Southern Baptist Convention contains both columns: the traditional statement reads right, the New Calvinist wing reads left, and that is why two Baptist churches on the same road can disagree about this. · The word for the left-hand column is *monergism*, one worker. The word for the right is *synergism*, working together. Everything else tonight is vocabulary for these three lines.

The Atonement Compendium

Everything you have taught and written on the cross, in one place

Assembled 2026-09-13 from the 2022 Cross series and its brief, the 2022 small-group leader guide, the 23-slide Atonement Theories deck, the fall 2023 “What We Believe” class, the 2021 Doctrine of Sin outline, the 2012 candidacy answers, and your atonement locus in the Mind Map vault.

1. The frame you always use

You do not teach the theories as a menu. You teach them as **incomplete explanations of an uncontested fact**, and you say so up front. From the 2022 series brief, in your own words:

“A theory is a speculative explanation of a known fact that guides our response to that fact. The simple uncontested fact of the scriptures is that ‘Jesus died for our sins.’”

“The best atonement theories have strong scriptural foundations and long histories of inspiring faithful response and action in Christians, but none of these explanations can substitute or stand in for the cross itself. Every explanation is incomplete. As the saying goes in science: all theories are wrong, but some are useful.”

And the instruction to the congregation, which is the posture of the whole thing:

“our reason for describing them is not for you to pit them against one another, or choose one over the other. I can’t think of anything more useless than converting you to a theory.”

The painting analogy

The best single image you have written for this, and it is sitting unused in the 2022 brief:

“I hope that we will sustain our attention to the cross in the same way that a great painting captures our attention. In one moment, we are right up to it to see the shape of the brush strokes. In the next moment we step back to take the whole picture in one glimpse. And in yet another moment, we look carefully at the way light falls in the painting. And when we try to find words for why we love a painting, it is not because we think those words will substitute for the painting itself. Instead, the right words illuminate and glorify the painting, helping us to see what was there all along.”

That paragraph does in six sentences what a lecture on theological method does in thirty minutes.

The two mistakes

Also from the brief, and worth saying out loud in any room:

“Culturally, American Christians have tended to make two equal and opposite mistakes when talking about the cross. The first mistake is to turn it into a tool for spiritual abuse, to emphasize its horror and agony and Christ’s sacrifice in such a way as to guilt trip someone into honoring Jesus or compel compliance. The second mistake is to diminish the cross so profoundly that the only way we know how to speak of resurrection and God’s love is through language that sounds too much like the power of positive thinking, and elides the call that Christ has given every Christian to take up your cross and follow me.”

2. The five theories, as you have actually taught them

Every one of these carries four things in your material: a plain claim, a felt need it answers, a named incompleteness, and a discipleship consequence. That four-part structure is the most valuable thing in the whole corpus and it is entirely yours.

Ransom

Preached as: “Jesus died to pay our debt.” John 8:31-36, with Colossians 2:13-15. **The claim:** Jesus redeems us from a debt of slavery to sin and death. **The felt need:** feeling trapped. “As if we’ll be forever paying down old mistakes rather than building something new and good.” **The incompleteness you name:** it makes the devil, death, and sin seem very powerful, maybe more powerful than God, because it forced God to act. **Discipleship consequence:** freedom, including the freedom to take up the cross without fearing what you lose. This week was tied to the RIP Medical Debt campaign, which made the theory literal. **Earliest form:** Origen, Gregory of Nyssa. Largely retired in modern theology, with echoes surviving in Eastern Orthodoxy.

Christus Victor

Preached as: “Jesus died to conquer death.” Mark 3:23-27, with 1 Peter 3:19-22. **The claim:** Jesus redeems us by proving himself stronger than death and conquering it. “The atonement theory that most demonstrates the active nature of God’s goodness.” **The felt need:** feeling too weak, untalented, or diminished by your own flaws to be useful to God. **The incompleteness you name:** it suggests might makes right. God is not bound by any promise in this model, God simply does what God wants, which makes it hard to know how to trust God. The 2022 leader guide adds a second limit: it says what God is against rather than what God is for, and asks little of us. **Discipleship consequence:** the church as an army guaranteed to win, fighting with love and forgiveness and resurrection rather than with weapons. “All our defeats are temporary, and his victory is permanent.” **Your own additions, from your copy only:** “the Kingdom is built on empathy,” and the tie to the funeral liturgy, “Dying, Christ destroyed our death.” **The wild card in this week:** Warren Smith’s “commando raid on hell,” from 1 Peter, the gospel reaching the already dead. The most universalism-adjacent line in your corpus.

Satisfaction

Preached as: “Jesus died to keep our promise.” Matthew 26:38-40, with Philippians 2:5-11. **The claim:** Jesus pays what we owe *God*, which is what distinguishes it from ransom. God kept drawing the covenant narrower, willing to accept a faithful nation or a faithful king, and we could not produce one faithful person. So Jesus came to be the faithful one. **The felt need:** that there is nothing and no one you can truly depend on, and that once you are no longer useful or productive you will be forgotten. **The incompleteness you name:** it does not describe our agency at all. Ransom gives us

freedom and Christus Victor gives us power, and satisfaction “almost leaves us with nothing to do. Deprived not only of power and freedom, but even purpose.” You also note that substitution theories do not clearly account for the resurrection. **Discipleship consequence:** keeping promises and keeping faith with each other even when it costs. You reach for the Benedictine vow of stability here. **The compression worth keeping:** “Jesus died to keep the promise we couldn’t.” **Source:** Anselm, eleventh century. Foundational for Roman Catholic and classical Anglican atonement theology.

Penal substitution

Preached as: “Jesus died to show God’s justice.” Romans 3:21-26, with Galatians 3:12-13. **The claim:** Jesus suffers the punishment God was honor-bound to inflict. **The analogy you used:** speeding. We know the limit and ignore it when it is not enforced, so God must enforce the moral law in some way to testify that it is wrong. **The felt need:** that some things are so wrong they make us angry, and we want them answered. **The two incompletenesses you name:** first, like ransom, it limits God’s power and makes God beholden to our idea of justice. “God does not literally *have* to punish sin. A sovereign God can simply forgive whatever God wants.” Second, and this is the sharper one, “the PSA theory too quickly becomes an excuse for sacrificing other people rather than ourselves. Whenever we expect someone else to bear the burden of our convenience, righteousness, or dreams, we are creating an unholy substitute.” **Discipleship consequence:** to cry out for justice, even at cost. **The two guardrails you always install:** - N. T. Wright’s trinitarian correction: “God was not sending someone else to die in our place. Instead, in Jesus, God was dying in our place.” - The anti-abuse guardrail: “To properly understand the cross we must never forget that it was God on the cross; it was God making the sacrifice. God has never demanded that you suffer for God’s pleasure or satisfaction. God has always placed himself alongside those who suffer.”

Note that this is the **only** theory in your series introduced with an extended preamble before the content. That asymmetry is deliberate and it is worth keeping.

Girard, the scapegoat or mirror theory

Preached as: “Jesus died because we killed him.” Mark 15:6-15, with John 11:49-50. **The Palm Sunday slot, the climax of the series. The claim:** “This theory emphasizes that the cross is something that *we* did to Jesus, rather than something God did to Jesus. What Jesus did was to *forgive* us for the cross.” **The felt need:** understanding why we live in a world where people are divided and looking for scapegoats. **The operative image, from Tony Jones:** “On the cross God is holding up a huge mirror and what we see is our own violence reflected back at us.” **Your own line on the mechanism:** “In Penal, God needs blood sacrifice. But the truth is that we are the ones who need our wrath assuaged. So Jesus steps in and says I will be that scapegoat. This theory does not attribute any violence to God.” **Discipleship consequence:** refusing to participate in scapegoating, and remembering that the enemy is not the neighbor Jesus came to save but the powers of sin in each of our hearts. “We offer ourselves as a living sacrifice because we are committed to stop sacrificing others.” **Your Palm Sunday ending, in your manuscript only:** “The cross was the sacrificial undoing of sacrifice,” and “Only through finding reconciliation with each other will we all be reconciled to God.” **Background reading you assigned:** “The Unlikely Christianity of René Girard” by Pascal-Emmanuel Gobry.

3. Where you actually land

The pluralism is real and it is a position rather than a dodge. But underneath it there is a weighting, in two layers.

The lower layer is a Christus Victor lean. When you preach the cross without a survey series to run, you reach for victory language. The greatest victory that has ever been. Even the Revelation imagery, the beat-up little bitty lamb who nonetheless emerges victorious.

The upper layer, and increasingly the one doing the work, is the Girard-and-Jones axis. Girard gets the climactic slot. Tony Jones's mirror is the image you reach for. Gregory Jones supplies the constructive account. If anything in your system outranks Christus Victor in actual usage, it is this.

The engine underneath all of it is forgiveness:

"Forgiveness is power. It is not weakness; it is not a nice courtesy. It is the power that Jesus unleashed on the cross. Forgiveness is the power God uses to save us."

And the frame is at-one-ment, both directions at once. You tie the vertical and the horizontal together through the word's own etymology, which is why your atonement material always runs straight into ethics:

"The Cross is the only hope for real peace, real unity, real atonement, real at-one-ment. Reconciliation between God and the humanity that is made in God's image."

Horizontal reconciliation is not an application of the atonement in your system. It is part of it.

4. The Wesleyan synthesis you use: Gregory Jones

From the 23-slide deck and taught again in the fall 2023 class. You have twice put this in writing as **"a contemporary United Methodist understanding of atonement,"** which makes it the closest thing you have to a stated landing place.

Jones, *Embodying Forgiveness: A Theological Analysis*. The argument in sequence:

1. **The image of God is the capacity for relationship.** The Trinitarian God endows humans with the ability to be in relationship, realized fully in communities marked by justice and peace.
2. **Sin is the refusal to live according to that image.** It grows from fear, faithlessness, and greed, and expresses itself as a will to power. Violence is its ultimate form, but so is every manipulation, oppression, injustice, and exploitation.
3. **Sin makes healthy relationship impossible.** It destroys trust, isolates the self, breeds guilt and the desire to judge, and turns people into victims and victimizers. War, racism, and economic injustice are the outward and visible signs of an inward and spiritual disease.
4. **Sin becomes the human condition by habituation.** Violence becomes the norm, justice degrades into balancing the scales of retribution, and religion gets

co-opted by the powerful as self-justification and embraced by the powerless as sop.

5. **Atonement breaks the power of sin.** Following Barth, in the death of Jesus “the righteous judge allowed himself to be judged by unrighteous human beings.” Our judgment of Jesus turned out to be God’s judgment of us, and it was a judgment of grace rather than condemnation, intended to save rather than to punish.
6. **The resurrection answers violence with life rather than retribution.** God did not return death for death. Jesus was avenged not by the death of his enemies but by his own resurrection. Jesus refuses both the victim and the victimizer role, which breaks the cycle.
7. **Forgiveness is a way of life, not a feeling.** Jones rejects therapeutic forgiveness as mere relief from guilt. It is costly, painful, and requires maturity. “We are forgiven into forgiveness.”
8. **Forgiveness is unlimited except by our capacity to receive it,** never by God’s willingness.
9. **Embodying that forgiveness is the mission of the church.** Not imitating Jesus’s example, but participating in his resurrected life through the Holy Spirit.

Notice how cleanly that maps onto your own Girardian instincts. Jones is the constructive version of what Girard describes diagnostically.

5. How you got here, 2010 to 2026

This is a real change of mind over a decade, and it is worth telling from the front.

2010, St. James building-theology curriculum. Already teaching that atonement is “bigger than a forgiveness transaction,” and that the incarnation aims at “redemption for the entire world” rather than only the forgiveness of sins.

2011, the Akedah paper. Substitution and typology worked through Genesis 22, but by narrative rather than by mechanism.

2012 to 2013, the candidacy board. Flat, single-theory, transactional: “I believe that Jesus took the sins of all humans and that he died for those sins in order to pay the debt that we owed.” This is your board voice defaulting to the plainest available formula while the classroom voice had already moved past it.

2016, Huntingdon chapel. The cross as fulfillment of the law rather than a penal mechanism.

2018. The cross bound to the Genesis 15 covenant ritual, read as God’s one-sided absorption of covenant obligation.

2020, Power and Passion. “The Cross was an act of obedience toward us. In Jesus, God was making a covenant, a binding promise of love toward us.” The same season crystallizes the forgiveness engine.

2021, Mother’s Day. The Girardian reading stated explicitly: “We once demanded that someone be sacrificed on our behalf, and that person turned out to be the Son of God. And now, we dare not do that again.”

Lent 2022, The Cross. The whole kaleidoscope laid out in sequence, with the congregation explicitly told not to pick a winner, and Girard quietly given the climax.

Fall 2023, “What We Believe, And Why It Matters,” Week 2. The same five theories taught in a classroom, now with the Gregory Jones synthesis attached.

2024 to 2026, SFUMC. Consolidation rather than change. Substitutionary phrasing still surfaces in passing, always inside the kaleidoscopic and forgiveness-centered frame the 2022 series set.

The teaching move: in 2012 you gave a board one theory with no hedge. Ten years later you preached five and forbade the congregation to choose. Naming that from the front does more for a room than any list of models, because it shows them that a settled person’s mind can still move.

6. Where everything lives

Your own synthesis - Mind

Map/wiki/syntheses/theology-of-woods-lisenby/loci/atonement.md — the locus, with fifteen dated quotes - Mind

Map/wiki/syntheses/theology-of-woods-lisenby/loci/_raw/atonement.md — the raw quote slice behind it - Mind Map/wiki/sources/atonement-theories-study.md — the deck, summarized - Mind Map/wiki/sources/dwumc-sermon-series-2022-2023.md — the series analyzed - Mind Map/wiki/sources/dwumc-teaching-theology-2021-2023.md — the leader guide and the sin outline

The deck - ~/Desktop/SFUMC Info/Senior Pastor Things Misc/Atonement Theories.pdf, 23 slides, with Atonement.key alongside it - Staged copy: Miscellaneous Projects/AWFUMC Connectional Resource Hub/Vault-Staging/SFUMC_Adults_AtonementTheoriesDeck_2024.pdf

The 2022 Cross series, Sermons/2022/The Cross/ - The Cross_Brief.docx — the series brief. The most useful single file in the set - Ash Wednesday 2022.pages — edited March 2025 with “here in 2025,” so you re-preached it at SFUMC - Woods' Version - Jesus Died To Pay Your Debts.pages — Ransom - Mark 3_Christus Victor_Michael.docx — Christus Victor - Mtthw 26_Jesus Died to Keep our Promise.docx — Satisfaction - Romans3_Penal Substitution.rtf — Penal substitution - Jesus Died Because We Killed Him.pages — Girard - Jesus Died to Conquer Death .pages — Easter

Co-written with Michael Precht, then each of you preached your own edit. The .pages files are yours; the .docx and .rtf are his.

The small-group curriculum - Dropbox/Previous Work/Dauphin Way UMC/Adult Discipleship/Miscellaneous/Atonement.pdf — 31 pages, week by week, with videos, discussion, devotions, and a closing prayer

The 2023 class - Dropbox/.../Short Term Classes/What We Believe, And Why It Matters Week 2.pdf — sin, salvation, atonement, Jones - Week 3.pdf — ecclesiology, hell, the in-between, heaven

Feeder material - Dropbox/.../Miscellaneous/The Doctrine of Sin.pages and .pdf — October 2021, yours - Dropbox/.../Miscellaneous/Christus Victor.docx -

Dropbox/.../Miscellaneous/Explaining Atonement.pdf — a seminary handout you highlighted, not yours - 2012 candidacy answers, in the previous-ministry dossier

Charts, in Dropbox/.../Adult Discipleship/Charts and Docs/ - crucifixion parallels.pages, Christology.pages, Christian-Denominations-Family-Tree.png, Protestant-Spectrum-Final.png, Theological Spectrum.pdf, Church History Tree.pdf, UM Church History Flowchart.pdf

7. Lines you can use as they are

"A theory is a speculative explanation of a known fact that guides our response to that fact."

"All theories are wrong, but some are useful."

"Every one of the theories we will discuss has a biblical foundation, and every one has limits."

"I can't think of anything more useless than converting you to a theory."

"Jesus died to keep the promise we couldn't."

"It was God on the cross; it was God making the sacrifice. God has never demanded that you suffer for God's pleasure or satisfaction."

"The cross is something that we did to Jesus, rather than something God did to Jesus. What Jesus did was to forgive us for the cross."

"On the cross God is holding up a huge mirror and what we see is our own violence reflected back at us." (Tony Jones)

"The cross was the sacrificial undoing of sacrifice."

"Only through finding reconciliation with each other will we all be reconciled to God."

"Forgiveness is the power God uses to save us."

"Forgiveness came when Christ paid our debt and set us free from slavery to evil. Forgiveness came when Christ rose victorious after a metaphysical battle against death itself. But after all that there is also this. Forgiveness came when Jesus said 'I forgive you.'"

That last one is the whole compendium in four sentences, and you already wrote it.

Baptism, Historically

Week 5 background. How four positions came to exist, and in what order.

The thesis in one sentence

Infant baptism is the practice the whole church shared for roughly thirteen hundred years before anybody objected, and the two convictions your Baptist neighbor holds most firmly, believer's baptism only and immersion only, are the two most recent ideas in the entire story.

Your instinct was right, and the gap is bigger than most people in the room will guess.

Part one: the ancient evidence, and why it is stranger than people expect

What we do and do not have from the New Testament

The honest starting point, and say it plainly so nobody thinks you are hiding it. **There is no passage in the New Testament that describes the baptism of an infant, and no passage that forbids it.** Every baptism narrated in detail is of someone who responded to preaching.

What there is instead is the household formula, the *oikos* pattern: Lydia and her household (Acts 16:15), the Philippian jailer "and his entire household" (Acts 16:33), Crispus "together with all his household" (Acts 18:8), the household of Stephanas (1 Corinthians 1:16). Whether those households contained children is an inference either way. Both sides are arguing from silence and both should admit it.

The Didache, around AD 100

The earliest Christian manual outside the New Testament gives baptismal instructions, and what it actually says is more specific than the way it usually gets summarized. It gives a ranked list of water. Baptize in living or running water. If you do not have living water, use other water. If you cannot do it in cold, use warm. And **if you have neither, pour water on the head three times**, in the name of the Father and of the Son and of the Holy Spirit.

Note what the condition is, because this got stated loosely in an earlier draft and the loose version is wrong. The trigger for pouring is the *absence* of the preferred water, not a shortage of it. The chapter contains no word for "enough" and no word for "immersion." Checked against the Greek in Logos on 2026-09-14.

That single provision still matters enormously for your class, and stating it precisely makes it land harder. The earliest instruction manual we have, written while the apostolic generation was barely cold, authorizes pouring, specifies the form of it as three times on the head with the triune name, and calls the result baptism. No asterisk. No language marking it as irregular. No instruction to redo it properly later.

Then give the other side its due, out loud. The Didache ranks water, which implies something about the normal case. Why prefer running water and make pouring the fallback unless the default involved standing in it? That is a fair reading and you should grant it. What the Didache does not do is make the preferred mode a requirement or treat the fallback as a lesser baptism. That is the whole distinction, and it is narrower and more defensible than “the mode was flexible from the beginning.”

One detail the Catholic counterpoint will like: three times. Threefold pouring, and threefold immersion, is the older and wider practice in both East and West.

Tertullian, around AD 200, and the best evidence there is

Tertullian wrote a treatise *On Baptism* in which he **argues for delaying** the baptism of small children. He thinks it is better to wait, and he gives practical reasons.

VERIFIED 2026-09-14, and the chapter is now on disk. The Ante-Nicene Fathers are in the local corpus, so chapter 18 has been read rather than summarized. The earlier caution on this page is withdrawn, and the narrower claim it recommended turns out to be the right one. His sentence is this: “according to the circumstances and disposition, and even age, of each individual, the delay of baptism is preferable; principally, however, in the case of little children.” His reasons are prudential. The sponsors take on a promise they may not live to keep and may be let down by how the child turns out; children should come when they are able to know Christ; and he asks why “the innocent period of life” should hurry toward the remission of sins. The chapter closes, “If any understand the weighty import of baptism, they will fear its reception more than its delay.” Source: *On Baptism* 18, Ante-Nicene Fathers vol. 3, public domain, at anf03:67303 in the corpus.

Here is the move worth making slowly in the room. **You do not write an argument against a practice nobody is doing.** Our clearest early evidence that the church was baptizing infants is a document objecting to it. Tertullian is a hostile witness, which makes him a better witness. By 200 the practice was common enough in North Africa that a major theologian felt the need to push back.

And here is what reading the actual chapter buys you, which is the part worth having in your pocket. Tertullian is not arguing that infant baptism is invalid. He is arguing that it is unwise, and his whole case rests on a concession he made two chapters earlier, that baptism is not strictly necessary for salvation. He also never suggests the practice is new or that nobody does it. Better still, in the same breath he urges the same delay for **the unmarried and the widowed**, on the grounds that they are exposed to sexual temptation and should wait until they marry or are strengthened for continence. So his objection is not a doctrine of believer’s baptism at all. It is a general caution about baptizing anyone whose future conduct is still uncertain. If somebody in the room claims Tertullian as the early witness for the Baptist position, that is the fact to have ready, gently: the same paragraph would have made them wait to baptize single adults too.

Hippolytus, around AD 215

The *Apostolic Tradition* gives an order of service for baptisms and instructs that the children be baptized first, and that those who can speak for themselves should, and for those who cannot, their parents or someone from the family should speak. That is infant baptism, described matter-of-factly in a liturgical manual, as ordinary procedure.

Attribution caution. This text is not in your Logos library in any edition, so the detail above is a paraphrase of a summary. It is the standard account and I have no reason to doubt it, but if you want to say it from the front, either attribute it loosely as a liturgical order usually dated to the early third century, or leave it out and let Tertullian, Origen, and Cyprian carry the ancient case. They can.

Origen, around AD 248

Origen states that the church received from the apostles the tradition of baptizing infants. He may be wrong about the apostolic origin. But he is reporting what the church of his day believed about its own practice, which is itself evidence about how settled the practice was.

Cyprian and Carthage, 253

A bishop writes asking whether baptism should wait until the eighth day, on the model of circumcision. A council of bishops answers no, do not delay, baptize the newborn.

Notice what is being argued about. Not whether to baptize infants. **When.** The question of legitimacy is not on the table.

The fourth century complication, which you should include

Do not oversimplify this. In the fourth century, **deliberate delay of baptism became common**, and not because people doubted infant baptism. It was because post-baptismal sin was taken so seriously that people postponed baptism as long as possible, sometimes to the deathbed. Constantine was baptized as he was dying. Augustine, raised by a Christian mother, was not baptized until he was in his thirties. Ambrose was baptized as an adult.

So the fourth century shows both practices running at once, and for reasons that have nothing to do with the modern argument. Including this makes you trustworthy. Leaving it out makes your case look tidier than the evidence is.

Augustine and the settlement, early fifth century

The Pelagian controversy is what ends the ambiguity. If infants are born into a condition they did not choose and cannot escape on their own, then baptizing them follows. Infant baptism becomes theologically grounded rather than merely customary, and in 418 a council at Carthage condemned the denial of infant baptism for the remission of sin.

From here to the Reformation there is no live dispute in the Western church. For eleven hundred years.

Part two: the medieval settlement

Baptism becomes one of seven sacraments, a list that firms up in the twelfth century with Peter Lombard and is formally enumerated at Florence in 1439. Baptism is the gateway, the one that makes the others possible, and it is understood to regenerate.

Two notes worth carrying into the room.

The mode drifted without a fight. Immersion remained common in the West well into the Middle Ages and gave way to pouring gradually, for practical reasons, without any

council declaring it. Nobody split a church over it. That fact is the strongest thing you can say when the mode question comes up on Sunday.

The East went its own way and kept everything. Orthodox practice baptizes infants by immersion, then chrismates them, then communes them, all in one service. An Orthodox baby receives the eucharist. Naming that breaks the assumption that infant baptism and immersion are opposites.

Part three: 1525, and the four positions

Everything that is not already on the table appears in about a hundred and twenty years.

Anabaptist, and the birth of believer's baptism only

January 21, 1525, Zurich. Conrad Grebel baptized George Blaurock, who then baptized others in the room. There was no ordained minister present to do it, which was rather the point. These were Zwingli's own students who had concluded that a church of the baptized should be a church of the willing.

The **Schleitheim Confession**, February 24, 1527, makes it an article: baptism is for those who have learned repentance, amended their lives, and ask for it themselves.

The word *Anabaptist* means rebaptizer, and it was an accusation rather than a self-description. They did not think they were baptizing twice. They thought infant baptism was not baptism.

Say what it cost them. Felix Manz became the first Anabaptist martyr in 1527, executed by drowning, which his executioners considered a fitting joke. George Blaurock was burned at the stake in 1529. They were persecuted by Catholics and by Protestants alike. Whatever you conclude about their theology, these were people who died for it within two years of proposing it.

Reformed, and baptism as covenant sign

Zwingli and then Calvin kept infant baptism and rebuilt the argument for it on different ground. Not that the water regenerates, but that baptism is the **sign and seal of the covenant**, standing where circumcision stood. If the children of Abraham received the covenant sign in infancy, and the new covenant is better rather than narrower, then withholding it from children would be a step backward.

This is the position most people have never heard, and it is worth teaching carefully, because it means a Presbyterian is on your side of the font for reasons that are not Catholic reasons at all.

Lutheran and Anglican, and baptism as a means of grace

Luther kept infant baptism and kept regeneration with it. Baptism genuinely does something, God's promise is attached to it, and its efficacy does not depend on the strength of anyone's faith, which is exactly why an infant is a good candidate. Anglicans held a similar position through the Articles of Religion.

And then everyone else stayed put

This is the line that lands. **Rome kept baptizing babies. Constantinople kept baptizing babies. Wittenberg, Geneva, and Canterbury all kept baptizing babies.** The Reformation is a fight about nearly everything, and on this one question the reformers who disagreed with each other about grace, the supper, and church government all landed in the same place.

The English Baptists, 1609 onward

A separate stream, not descended from the Anabaptists. **John Smyth**, an English Separatist exile in Amsterdam, concluded in 1609 that baptism required a profession of faith, and having no one to baptize him, baptized himself. He is known as the Se-Baptist for it. **Thomas Helwys** broke with Smyth and brought the congregation back to London in 1612, founding the first Baptist church on English soil.

And here is the detail that matters most for your class. Smyth almost certainly baptized by pouring, not immersion. The first Baptists were not immersionists. Immersion came in among English Baptists in the 1640s, and the firm anchor is the **First London Confession, issued by seven London Baptist churches in October 1644**, which specifies dipping.

So the sequence is: believer's baptism in 1525, and immersion as the required mode more than a century later. **The two are separate arguments that got fused so tightly that most people now assume they are one.** Prying them apart is the single most useful thing you can do in the room on this subject.

Part four: the mode question, separately

Treat this as its own conversation, because historically it is one.

- The Didache, around 100, permits pouring.
- The ancient church immersed where it could, and did not treat it as essential.
- The West drifted to pouring over centuries, with no council and no schism.
- The East immersed and still does, including infants.
- The first English Baptists poured.
- Immersion became a required mode in the 1640s.

The Greek *baptizo* does mean to dip or plunge, and the Baptist argument from the word is a real argument worth stating at full strength. The historical answer is that the church, including the people who spoke Greek natively, did not read the word as excluding other modes when circumstances required them.

And here is the better answer, because it is exegetical rather than historical, and because it is ours. Wesley took this question up directly in *A Treatise on Baptism*, and section 2 is the sentence to have in front of you. He says baptism is performed "by washing, dipping, or sprinkling," and his reason is that "it is not determined in Scripture in which of these ways it shall be done," neither by express precept, nor by any clear example, nor by the force or meaning of the word itself. *Works*, volume 10, p. 188, which you own.

He then argues it out rather than asserting it. John baptized at Enon where there was much water, and Wesley suggests that may describe breadth rather than depth, since a

narrow place could not have held so large a crowd. Philip and the eunuch both went down to the water, and Wesley says the going down may refer to the chariot and tells you nothing about depth. It might be up to their knees, he says, or not above their ankles. Then he points to 1 Corinthians 10:2, where the Jews were all baptized in the cloud and in the sea without being plunged into either.

Notice the shape of the move, because it is worth imitating. Wesley concedes the weak ground first, that Scripture gives no express precept, and only then argues that the word will not carry the weight placed on it. In a room with Baptists in it, conceding first is what buys you a hearing.

Part five: where Methodists land, and why

Wesley wrote a **Treatise on Baptism**, published 1756 and adapted from his father Samuel's earlier work. He affirmed infant baptism and a real efficacy in it. He also preached the new birth relentlessly, which produces the tension every Methodist lives with: baptism genuinely conveys grace, and a baptized person still needs to be converted.

Wesley's resolution is the one we still use. Baptism is the beginning of the life of grace rather than its completion. It is prevenient grace applied with water, which is why the whole week five argument links back to week three. God acts first, before the child can respond, and the response still has to come.

The current official position is "By Water and the Spirit," adopted by General Conference in 1996. If you only read one denominational document before Sunday, read that one. It is the reason we do not rebaptize, and it supplies the pastoral alternative: reaffirmation and remembrance of baptism rather than repetition of it.

That is the payoff for the room. When a Methodist who was baptized as an infant has a genuine adult conversion and wants to be baptized again, we say no, and it sounds like bureaucratic stubbornness unless you can explain it. The explanation is that **baptism is God's act, not ours, and God does not need to do it twice.** What we offer instead is a service where you reaffirm what God already did.

Part six: the modern moment

Baptism, Eucharist and Ministry, the Lima text of the World Council of Churches, 1982. The most significant ecumenical convergence document on this subject, and it asked both sides a hard question. It asked infant-baptizing churches whether they were baptizing indiscriminately, without any real expectation of formation. And it asked believer's-baptism churches to consider whether they were undervaluing God's initiative.

Worth naming, because it shows the argument is not frozen.

Teaching the Baptist case at full strength

Per the house rule, and this is the week it matters most, because the history runs against them and it would be easy to be smug.

State it this way, and mean it:

- Every baptism described in any detail in the New Testament is of a person who heard, believed, and asked. The household texts are an inference, and inference is not narration.
- The word itself means to dip.
- The church's drift toward universal infant baptism coincides exactly with the rise of Christendom, when baptism became the civic ritual that made you a citizen as much as a Christian. Their charge is that the practice grew because it was useful to the empire, and that is not a frivolous charge.
- A church of the baptized ought to be a church of the willing. Whatever the antiquity of the alternative, that is a serious ecclesiological conviction, and people died for it in 1527.

Then the honest concession you should make out loud: antiquity is not the same as correctness. A practice being very old does not make it right, and Baptists have always known the argument from history runs against them and have answered that the New Testament outranks the second century. That is a coherent position, and it is precisely the authority question from week one showing up again. Point that out. It ties the series together.

Discussion prompts for this section

- Tertullian argued for delaying the baptism of babies in the year 200, which is how we know people were doing it. What else might we only know about because somebody complained?
 - If your baptism was something God did rather than something you did, does it change how you think about the fact that you cannot remember it?
 - The church argued about *when* to baptize infants for a thousand years before it argued about *whether*. Why do you think the *whether* question waited until 1525?
 - Immersion became required in the 1640s, and the first Baptists poured. Does knowing that change how much weight the mode should carry?
 - What would you say to someone who told you your baptism did not count?
-

Source status, after the Logos check and the corpus build of 2026-09-14

Full detail, with the Greek and the citations, is in Week5-Logos-Verification.md.

Now verified in your own library, safe to assert from the front.

1. **Didache 7 and the pouring provision.** Checked against both the English and the Greek. This also corrected the draft, which had the condition wrong. See the Didache section above.

2. **That John Smyth baptized by pouring in 1609.** The *Essential Lexham Dictionary of Church History* states the mode explicitly. This was the first item on the unverified list and it is now off it.
3. **The First London Confession of 1644.** Two library sources give the date.
4. **Wesley on mode.** Quoted from *Works* volume 10, p. 188.

Still unverified, and handle accordingly.

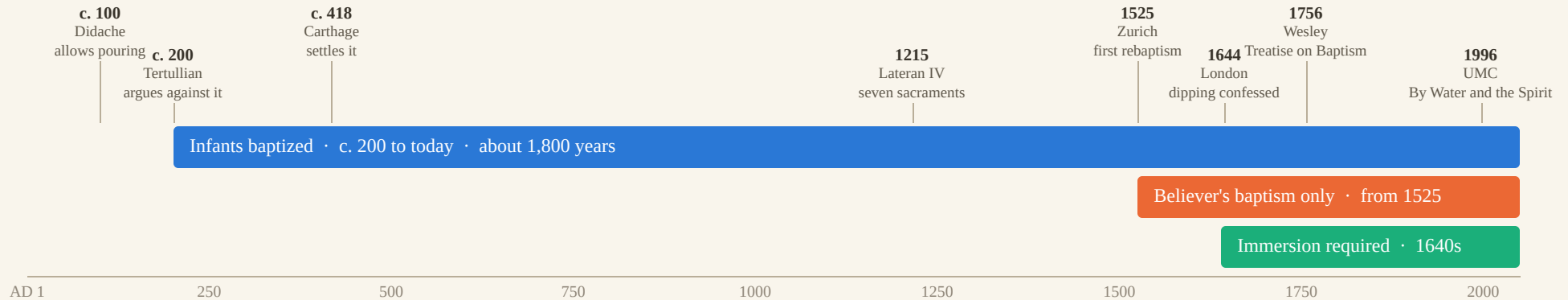
1. **The specific year 1641** for English Particular Baptists adopting immersion. It appears nowhere in your library, and a proximity search across all 516 resources turned up nothing. The confession's text, which is where the immersion language sits, is not in the library either. Say 1644.
2. ~~**Tertullian, *On Baptism* 18.**~~ **RESOLVED 2026-09-14, later the same day.** Not in Logos, but the Ante-Nicene Fathers are now in the local public-domain corpus and the chapter has been read in full. Quote it directly. See the Tertullian section above.
3. **Hippolytus, *Apostolic Tradition*.** Not in the library in any edition. Attribute loosely or leave it out.
4. **Cyprian's synod.** Your draft says 253. Wiley's *Christian Theology* says 254 with sixty-six bishops present. Both dates circulate. Pick one knowingly.

Verified earlier and unchanged: the January 21, 1525 Zurich rebaptism and the names involved, Manz as the first Anabaptist martyr in 1527, Blaurock burned in 1529, the Schleithem Confession of February 24, 1527, Smyth's 1609 self-baptism, Helwys in London in 1612, and the First London Confession issued by seven churches in October 1644.

How the Church Got Four Views of Baptism

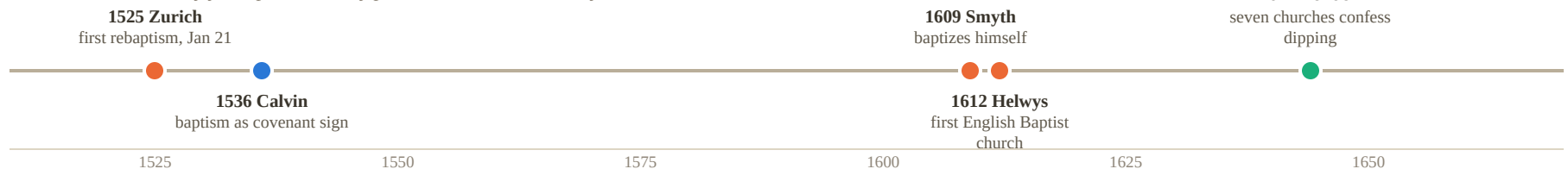
The two things your Baptist neighbor holds most firmly are the two newest ideas on this page.

■ Infants baptized ■ Believer's baptism only ■ Immersion required



Where all the new ideas happen

One hundred and twenty years produce every position that did not already exist.



THE POINT: infant baptism is not a Catholic invention bolted on later. It is the practice the whole church shared, in every place, for thirteen hundred years before anybody objected, and our best early evidence for it is a man arguing against it. Believer's baptism as the only valid baptism begins in one Swiss city in 1525. Requiring immersion is younger still, and the first Baptists themselves poured. Rome, Constantinople, Wittenberg, Geneva, Canterbury, and Wesley all kept baptizing babies. That does not settle the argument. It does change who has to explain themselves.

Dates for the ancient period are approximate, as ancient dates are. Two items to check before you assert them: the mode John Smyth used in 1609 (very likely pouring rather than immersion) and the commonly cited 1641 date for English Particular Baptists adopting immersion. The firm anchor for immersion is the First London Confession, issued by seven London Baptist churches in October 1644.